Week 11

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 3 · LESSON 3

DNA

BIG IDEA

Halfway through the science unit, pause and take stock of your relationships and of how well students are really following. Slow down where you need to, and use the provided misconceptions and simple examples to make hard ideas clear.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Check your relationships: are you building a culture where questions are welcome, students are honest with you and each other, and faith is growing?
2. Notice whether those relationships are deepening, whether new students are coming in, and how well they're fitting in.
3. Ask how students are tracking. Some nod along without getting it, some are fired up and asking great questions, and many are somewhere in between.
4. Don't be afraid to slow down, adapt and revisit concepts. Don't move forward until you're sure your students are ready.
5. The provided misconceptions are a window into the narrative students meet in their school textbooks, even if not in those exact words.
6. Choose examples that simplify hard ideas. The best one is Sean's simple description of a book to help us understand DNA.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. How are my relationships with students really going, and who have I lost track of?
2. Where might my students be nodding along without truly understanding?
3. Which concept from this unit do I need to slow down and revisit before moving on?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. How did comparing DNA to a book help you understand it, and what still feels unclear?
2. What have you been taught in school about where DNA and life came from?
3. Which part of this science unit has made the most sense to you so far, and which the least?
4. What questions about science and faith do you still have that we haven't covered?
5. What would make it easier for you to ask honest questions in this group?

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WEEK 11 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Halfway through the science unit

0:05 So here we are, about halfway through the science unit. I want to stop for a minute and get an idea of how you guys are doing. I want you to take a minute and think about a couple of things. One, how are your relationships doing? We've talked since the beginning about forming good relationships and creating a culture where questions are welcome, where students are being honest with you and with one another, and where their faith is developing. So take a step back, take some time this week, and analyze how that's going. Are your relationships furthering? Are they getting better? Are new students coming in? How are they assimilating? Those types of things.

How students are tracking

0:46 The second thing is, how are students tracking? Now let's be honest: this is not easy. So ask yourself, and maybe even ask some of your students, how are they tracking? Is it all making sense, or do they just kind of nod their heads like they get it, but in the back of their minds they're going, I don't get it? Or are they super fired up, digging for more and asking great questions? Or are you everywhere in between? It's very possible. It could be all over the spectrum.

1:17 But take a second, stop, and think about where your students are, which leads to asking yourself: do I need to slow it down? Do I need to adapt things a little bit? Don't be afraid to pull back and revisit some concepts. Make sure there's understanding. Go back and ask some questions, and figure out and make sure that your students are exactly where you need them to be so that you can move forward successfully. Don't move forward until you are certain that your students are ready to do so.

Two things to keep in mind

1:52 As you and your students are navigating some of these difficult waters, I want you to keep in mind two really important things. The first is the misconceptions that we've provided. These misconceptions are a clear window into the world of what your students are actually being taught. Now, they may not be taught these exact quotes or reading these exact things, but the stuff that we're quoting, the stuff that we're citing, is the underlying narrative that your students are reading about in textbooks in school.

Examples that simplify

2:24 The second thing is the examples that you use. It's so important, if you can, to use the right kind of examples to simplify some of these difficult concepts and make them a little bit easier

to understand. And the best example really is Sean's use of simply describing a book to help us understand DNA.